A Big Mean Pair of Scissors

By Quinn Cummings

I grew up in the hills above West Hollywood. Every Halloween, my mother and I would make a lonely trek through the neighborhood where, at any given house, my "Trick or Treat!" would produce a man dressed as either Maria Callas * or Marilyn in *The Seven Year Itch* *. For a long moment, he would stare at me in confusion then say something like, "Everyone, come here and look! It's a child!" At which point more men in festive regalia would crowd the doorway and goggle at me for a bit, apparently having forgotten there was another segment of the population allowed one night a year to wear something ridiculously bright and sparkly out in public without recrimination.

I always liked the men in our neighborhood. I had every intention of growing up to be a gay man in the West Hollywood hills. They had gorgeous clothing, gorgeous houses, gorgeous boyfriends, and gorgeous dogs.

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[It was] Not long after I turned fourteen, [that] I saw one of the longer-time residents out walking his dog. I hadn't seen him in many weeks and I was shocked. He had lost twenty pounds at least, and there were coal-black rings under his eyes. Something told me not to ask. He was dead within a month. He was the first person I knew who died of AIDS. I don't remember who the second and third were, because they started going so quickly. I stopped noticing the sound of the ambulance racing up our hill.

AIDS was a big mean pair of scissors in West Hollywood.

INTRODUCTION

More than 35 years ago, AIDS was called "The Gay Plague," gay cancer, or GRID (gay-related immune disorder). Sadly, because AIDS was first detected in homosexual males, it was largely dismissed because gay men circa 1980 were viewed as dispensable. The medical community considered this a homosexual disease, neither fashionable nor prestigious, and consequently unworthy of serious attention. They were wrong!

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The most recent statistics compiled by the UN in 2015 reports that 36.7 million people worldwide are now living with HIV/AIDS, of these, 1.8 million are under the age of 15. Nearly 22 million people have died of AIDS-related causes since the epidemic began.

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I made a decision: I was going to stop AIDS. I was eighteen, I had no medical training and a habit of covering my eyes and squealing when they inserted a fake IV on hospital dramas, but these were incidental details I could overcome. I was going to stop AIDS.

As it turned out, the workers at the front lines of the battle against AIDS didn't fall to their knees and scream "HUZZAH! She's arrived!" when I called AIDS Project Los Angeles. What they said was, "We need help in the office. Can you file?"

I sulked a bit. I can file, but where's the life-saving potential in that? "Anything else?"

I could hear him flipping through pages. "Oh, you're in luck," he finally said, "there's a hotline training class starting this week."

"Hotline?"

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"Yeah, we have a national hotline for information and support. It can be anything from finding a local clinic for people to get tested to helping someone who's just gotten a positive test result to . . . everything, really."

I would work the hotline. I would give people valuable information. I would be useful.

I had several weeks of training before they'd let me answer a phone. In a class of several dozen, I was one of three women. I was the youngest trainee by eight years. I brought several sharpened pencils and a notebook with "Hotline" carefully printed across the front. One of these facts made the teacher pick on me from day one.

He was gorgeous-a six-foot-five-inch-tall black man with the effortless grace of an athlete and the humor and affect of a very tall and very tan Bette Midler. Near the end of every class, he would bring one of us up front to roleplay a hotline call, with him as the caller and the student assuming his or her role as hotline advisor. Of course, being all

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enthusiasm and no experience, I was summoned to the front of the class four times out of five. I was a golden retriever puppy taking on Chernobyl.

I persevered. After forty hours of class, I had a working knowledge of the major and most of the minor sexual habits of the North American Homo erectus. I had also developed the ability to work needle-cleaning protocol into casual conversation. We, as a class, were ready to serve, but the teacher had one final lesson to impart. He leaned against a chair, crossing his arms and his endless legs, and looked at us deeply. "Four friends of mine and I sat in an apartment and started what has become this organization. I'm the only one left. I don't know why I'm still alive, but I do know why I'm still able to work here. I go to the gym every morning. I put on my Walkman, and I don't talk to anyone, and I don't think about this place. You went through this because you want to help, but don't overdo it. The hotline takes more out of you than you know." He then lectured us on the symptoms of burnout, which I

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carefully wrote down in my "Hotline" notebook so I could more effectively monitor my classmates in the months to come. I was going to be fine, but I could tell that some of these people weren't going to be able to keep things in proper balance.

My first shift was on a Saturday morning. I sat at a cubicle with a three-inch-thick binder in front of me, which represented the sum total of medical information and support for AIDS patients in the entire United States. An inch of that represented California and another inch New York. The final inch was the other forty-eight states with a page or two for Canada. Within minutes, the phone rang and I answered, "AIDS hotline, how can I help you?" with only the tiniest quaver, all the while thinking *Please don't be crying, please don't be crying, please be something I can answer.*

A brisk male voice said, "Hi, I need to get tested in Orange County, California." I nearly giggled in delight but checked the impulse, deciding this was not the image I wanted to present. I gave him his

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testing options, wished him luck, and hung up.

On the weekends, there was a steady stream of "Yeah, I had a teensy bit too much tequila last night, and I never do this, but . . . how long do I have to wait to get tested?"

If I worked a weekday, I'd get calls from suburban moms who had watched a documentary the previous night about how AIDS was about to inundate the heterosexual community, and who had spent the entire night obsessing over their college boyfriend who, in retrospect, might have liked musical theater just a *little too much.* Telling them how unlikely they were to have been exposed to AIDS in the early seventies at Iowa State would ease their fears, but they'd still want a local test site, which I would gladly provide.

About fifteen percent of the calls were the *Misfit Toys.* For these people, the hotline served as a form of solace and an unending source of entertainment. Thanks to our 1-800 number, they could pick up a phone and talk endlessly about their

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deeply held suspicions about how AIDS could be contracted from houseplants, or escalators, or doorknobs. Doorknob Guy was a frequent caller, and getting a new hotline volunteer was like Christmas and his birthday rolled into one. The new volunteer could be coaxed into a forty-five-minute trip down the rabbit hole where AIDS patients had sneezed into their hand-that sneeze carrying a trace of blood-then touched a doorknob and left AIDS viruses writhing and throbbing, waiting for their next victim.

The first time I got him, I spent almost half an hour before hanging up the phone, exhausted and headachy from trying to explain epidemiology to a lunatic, only to hear the phone in the cubicle next to mine ring. The phones rang in order and I just knew it was Doorknob Guy, fat and sassy from our conversation and hungry for a new victim. The volunteer next to me, a seasoned vet of several months, picked up the phone and said, "AIDS hotline, how can I help you?" He listened for a few seconds and then said waggishly, "Sweetie, it depends on what

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you do with that doorknob," then hung up sharply and turned to me, a pleasant expression on his face.

"And *that's* how you handle Doorknob Guy," he said with finality.

Not every phone call was productive; some were fairly unpleasant, thanks to the percentage of the population whose own version of Jesus hated us very much and needed us to know that. Nonetheless, each shift generated at least one call where I could tell myself, "I helped him

Within weeks, I'd grown polished and confident. I was a seasoned veteran. Nothing I heard surprised me. I was the one slamming shut Doorknob Guy to the wonder of the newer volunteers. I was never at a loss for words, never judgmental, never shocked. Every week, there were more people wanting to get tested, more people looking for health care after they'd tested positive, and more people calling for the list of mortuaries who would take people who had died of AIDS. In six months, the call volume doubled. I worked the phones, I heard stuff,

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and I kept it to myself.

There were group stress-reduction sessions for the hotline volunteers--but I never bothered to go. I was helping. I didn't need help.

The call came on a quiet weekday morning. The caller was sobbing so hard it took her a few minutes to collect herself enough to explain what she needed. She wasn't calling for herself. She was calling for a friend, a sorority sister. The entire sorority had gone, en masse, to get tested, and they got their results this morning. Her friend, eighteen and with one sexual partner, had tested positive. My brain raced. Was this a hoax? It didn't matter if it was; I had to treat it seriously either way. But if it was a hoax, this girl needed an agent. My inner lie detector said it was probably legit, the only question being whether this "friend" was, in fact, my caller. I asked what state she was in and when she told me, I nearly burst into tears myself. She was calling from the Southern state with only one page of medical and psychological support in place-actually half a page-and

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nothing specifically for women. I gave her what I had, and tried to calm her down enough to see this wasn't an ***immediate*** death sentence-although.

The call ended. I hung up, and then I stood up. I said to no one in particular, "I'm cutting out early," and I left. I got to the parking lot, sat in my car, and switched the radio off because I couldn't stand the noise. I then switched it back on because the silence was overwhelming. My brain couldn't find anywhere to land. I had started working at APLA (AIDS Project of Los Angeles) so I could help the gay community in which I had grown up and the addicts who weren't capable of shaking an addiction that was going to kill them unless they took care of themselves. This was the first phone call where it occurred to me that the ***them*** in the AIDS epidemic might look a lot like *me*. I couldn't save my neighbors or my fellow human beings, but what kind of an ass was I that it finally broke my heart when the caller looked like the person I saw in the mirror?

I stopped in to see the hotline supervisor and mumbled my complaints. The job wasn't any fun, or I

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wasn't good at it, and it was because I got this one call. I had been fine until this one stupid call, which made me feel itchy, sad, and really angry. Besides, everyone else kept talking when I was trying to take a call and no one ever made a fresh pot of coffee, which sucked even freshly made, and it would have been fine if I just hadn't gotten this one call. Finished, I slumped farther down in my seat. My mentor sighed deeply.

"How many support meetings did you attend?" he asked. *(silence)* "So, none. Lost enthusiasm for the job. Irritable. No longer confident in your ability, right? That college girl may have been your last straw, but it's burnout, Quinn. Remember? Take a month off. See if your heart is in it after that. You've been volunteering how long?"

I thought. "Six months." It seemed longer.

I took off a month, and then two. Three months later, I didn't go back. I beat myself up plenty over that. A few more neighbors were sick, a couple had died, and I still didn't go back. I didn't help because I couldn't help. A teenage girl with a notebook full of

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phone numbers wasn't going to change a damn thing.

CLOSING

More than thirty years ago AIDS was terrifying, deadly and spreading fast. Today, although we still haven't discovered a cure for AIDS, we do have the means to treat those who test positive for HIV, the virus that causes AIDS. A diagnosis of AIDS is no longer a death sentence; people can live long, happy and fulfilling lives with the proper treatment. Who knows . . . in the next 30 years maybe, just maybe, we will find a cure.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

- ***NOTE: More information and pictures of Maria Callas can be found at***

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http://www.biography.com/people/maria-callas-9235435

- ***NOTE: Marilyn Monroe's famous subway grate picture came from this movie – See pictures here http://www.biography.com/news/marilyn-monroe-seven-year-itch-dress-photos***

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